

MELLISSA MEISELS

Assistant Professor of Political Science
University of Michigan

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Appointments & Affiliations

UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

Assistant Professor, Department of Political Science 2026 –

YALE UNIVERSITY

Assistant Professor, Department of Political Science 2025 – 2026

Faculty Affiliate, Institution for Social and Policy Studies

Faculty Affiliate, Center for the Study of American Politics

Postdoctoral Associate, Center for the Study of American Politics 2024 – 2025

UNIVERSITY OF ROCHESTER

Visiting Scholar, Democracy Center 03/2023

Education

VANDERBILT UNIVERSITY

Ph.D. Political Science 2019 – 2024

FIELDS: American Politics, Political Methodology

COMMITTEE: Josh Clinton (chair), Larry Bartels, Alan Wiseman, Danielle Thomsen (UCI)

Graduate Affiliate, Center for the Study of Democratic Institutions

M.A. Political Science 2019 – 2022

UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES

B.A. Political Science, *magna cum laude* 2015 – 2018

ADVISOR: John Zaller

Peer-Reviewed Publications

Meisels, Mellissa. 2026. "Candidate Positions, Responsiveness, and Returns to Extremism." *Journal of Politics* 88(2): 681-697.

Meisels, Mellissa. 2026. "Everything in Moderation? The Effect of Extremist Nominations on Individual and Corporate PAC Fundraising." *Political Science Research and Methods* 14(2): 353-369.

Meisels, Mellissa. 2025. "Strategic Campaign Attention to Abortion Before and After *Dobbs*." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 122(20): e2503080122.

Meisels, Mellissa, Joshua D. Clinton, and Gregory A. Huber. 2024. "Giving to the Extreme? Experimental Evidence on Donor Response to Candidate and District Characteristics." *British Journal of Political Science* 54(3): 851-873.

Working Papers & Works in Progress

Campaign Agendas and Issue Group Strategy in Intraparty Elections (*Revise and resubmit, Quarterly Journal of Political Science*)

— 2023 Political Organizations and Parties Best APSA Paper Award

PRESENTATIONS: APSA MIP Pre-Conference 2023, APSA 2023, JAWS Fall 2023, MPSA 2024, UChicago Harris American Center for Effective Government Conference 2024

Estimating Consensus Ideal Points Using Multi-Source Data (*with Melody Huang and Tiffany M. Tang*) (*Revise and resubmit, American Journal of Political Science*)

PRESENTATIONS: PolMeth 2025

Competition and Free-Riding in Electoral Campaigns with Outside Spending (*with Brenton Kenkel*)

PRESENTATIONS: MPSA 2022, APSA MIP Pre-Conference 2022, APSA 2022, VFT 2023

Asymmetrically Polarized Threat of Replacement

PRESENTATIONS: MPSA 2026, APSA 2025

Intraparty Candidate Divergence and Primary Participation

PRESENTATIONS: CBS-Princeton Money in Politics Conference 2026, APSA 2026, PolMeth 2026

Do Participatory Campaign Finance Reforms Polarize? Evidence from the Seattle Democracy Voucher Program (*with Michael Kistner, Lautaro Cruz, and Kolbe Dumas*)

PRESENTATIONS: APSA 2026

The Increasing Importance of Congressional Primary Elections

— Invited chapter in 3rd edition of *New Directions in Congressional Politics*, eds. Jamie Carson and Michael Lynch (Routledge)

Other Publications

Mellissa Meisels. 2024. "Political Donors Prefer Extreme Candidates, but the Competitiveness of the Election and their Opponent's Views Matter Too." *LSE United States Politics & Policy Blog*.

Awards, Grants, & Fellowships

Founder's Medal for First Honors, Vanderbilt University	2025
Best APSA 2023 Paper Award, Political Organizations and Parties Section	2024
Provost's Pathbreaking Discovery Award, Vanderbilt University Graduate School	2024
Outstanding Doctoral Student Award, Vanderbilt University Graduate School	2024
Harold Stirling Vanderbilt Award, Vanderbilt University Graduate School	2022 – 2024
Russell G. Hamilton Scholar, Vanderbilt University Graduate School	2019 – 2024
Outstanding Graduate Research Paper Award, Vanderbilt Political Science	2023
Virginia Gray Graduate Student Research Award, APSA POP Section	2023
Conference Travel Grant, American Political Science Association	2023
J. Leiper Freeman Memorial Award, Vanderbilt Political Science	2023
NSF Travel and Participation Award, Society for Political Methodology	2023
Travel Grant, Vanderbilt University Graduate School	2023
University Graduate Fellowship, Vanderbilt University Graduate School	2019 – 2022
Research Assistant Funding, Vanderbilt ROCCA Lab	2022
NSF Travel and Participation Award, Society for Political Methodology	2022
Travel Grant, Vanderbilt University Graduate School	2022
J. Leiper Freeman Memorial Award, Vanderbilt Political Science	2021
Lew and Edie Wasserman Grant, UCLA Alumni Association	2016 – 2019
UCLA Alumni Scholarship, UCLA Alumni Association	2015 – 2019

Presentations

INVITED TALKS

American Politics Workshop, Northwestern University	05/2027
Department of Political Science, University of Michigan	03/2026
Research on Behavior and Institutions Conference, Vanderbilt University (<i>discussant</i>)	03/2026
Data Workshop, Department of Statistical Sciences, University of Toronto	11/2025
Weil, Gotshal & Manges Roundtable, Yale Law School (<i>discussant</i>)	11/2025
Center for the Study of American Politics Conference, Yale University (<i>discussant</i>)	06/2025
Center for the Study of Democratic Politics, Princeton University	03/2025
Center for Effective Government, UChicago Harris	06/2024
Department of Government, University of Texas at Austin	11/2023

Department of Political Science, Syracuse University	11/2023
Department of Political Science, University of California, San Diego	11/2023
Department of Political Science, Yale University	11/2023
Department of Political Science, Stanford University	11/2023
Department of Government, American University	10/2023
Department of Political Science, University of Rochester	03/2023

OTHER SMALL CONFERENCES & WORKSHOPS

CBS–Princeton Conference on Money in Politics	2026
Yale Political Science Junior Faculty Working Group	2025
Junior Americanist Workshop Series (JAWS)	2023
Virtual Formal Theory Workshop	2023
Vanderbilt Political Science IDEAS Symposium	2023
Vanderbilt American Politics Workshop	2022 – 2023
Money in Politics Pre-Conference, American Political Science Association	2021 – 2023

ANNUAL MEETINGS

Society for Political Methodology	2022, 2023, 2025, 2026
American Political Science Association	2021 – 2026
Midwest Political Science Association	2021 – 2026

Teaching

INSTRUCTOR OF RECORD, UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN

POLSCI 389 — Special Interest Politics in the US (U)	2027
POLSCI 688 — Special Interest Politics in the US (G)	2027

INSTRUCTOR OF RECORD, YALE UNIVERSITY

PLSC 3256/8050 — Elite Behavior in Congressional Elections (U/G)	2026
PLSC 2255 — Special Interest Politics in the US (U)	2025

TEACHING ASSISTANT, VANDERBILT UNIVERSITY

PSCI 3893 — American Democracy and Dissent	2024
PSCI 3244 — The Legislative Process	2023
PSCI 3260 — Introduction to American Law	2022
PSCI 2260 — Constitutional Law	2022
DSCI 1000 — Data Science: How Data Shape Our World	2021
PSCI 2300 — Introduction to Data Science for Politics	2021
PSCI 1150 — U.S. Elections	2020

Service

DEPARTMENT & UNIVERSITY

Faculty Mentor, U-M Undergraduate Research Opportunity Program	2026 – 2027
Committee Member, U-M Eldersveld Emerging Scholars Conference	2026
Graduate Admissions Committee, Yale Department of Political Science	2025 – 2026
Coordinator, Yale American Politics and Policy Workshop	2025 – 2026
Co-President, Vanderbilt Political Science Graduate Student Association	2021 – 2023

DISCIPLINE

Executive Council Member, APSA Political Organizations and Parties Section	2026 – 2028
Excellence in Mentoring Award Committee, Society for Political Methodology	2026
Poster Award Committee, Society for Political Methodology	2025
Referee for <i>Party Politics</i> , <i>Electoral Studies</i> , <i>Journal of Politics</i> , <i>American Journal of Political Science</i> , <i>Legislative Studies Quarterly</i> , <i>Political Behavior</i> , <i>American Political Science Review</i> , <i>Journal of Information Technology and Politics</i> , Brookings Institution Press, <i>Political Analysis</i>	